These volumes are about encountering a proverbial elephant – here symbolizing the seemingly sudden emergence in the mid-twelfth century of an obscure group from central Afghanistan into historical retrievability as the "Ghurids" – more accurately the Shansabanis (cf. below); and their even more amazing rise as they fashioned an empire extending from Herat in modern western Afghanistan to the Brahmaputra River in northeastern India–western Bangladesh. To date, the sequence of events leading to Shansabani ascendancy and the impetuses behind them are only partially known, however, the contemporaneous textual sources offering sometimes contradictory information or eliding them altogether (cf. Chapter 1). Furthermore, Shansabani architectural traces have been analyzed piecemeal, thus presenting a seemingly incomprehensible pastiche, not unlike Sana'i's elephant when perceived only through its individual parts. The present study essentially undertakes an *architectural biography* (see below): the two volumes bring together the corpus of Shansabani-patronized structures as among the primary historical sources with much to contribute toward our understanding of the Shansabanis, who were not only one of the "nomadic dynasties" emerging in Eurasia[6] as of the early second millennium CE, but an imperial formation impacting the subsequent trajectories of Central and South Asia.

Patronage of public or "civic" architecture such as *madrasa* complexes (Figure I.1) has been attributed to the Shansabanis, but their "capital" at



Figure I.1 *Remains of Shah-i Mashhad* madrasa*, Gharjistan (Badghis Province, Afghanistan). © Photograph Bernt Glatzer* c. *1970.*